

of symbiotic existence, both at the individual and the societal levels. Chatterjee is also known for her 'photo-sculpture' series during the pandemic, wherein she used kitchen ingredients to craft startling human forms.

"It often happens with young artists that their work feels as if theory has been vomited onto the canvas; it gets too literal," says Sarkar. "She [Chatterjee] has been trained as an art historian, but there's no baggage in her works. During the Covid lockdown, when she was confined to her house, she was doing her chores, running her kitchen, and so on; this is when the 'photo-sculptures' happened. As a creative person, she refused to let circumstances bog her down."

During a large-scale project that's simultaneously looking at the past and the future, it's only natural that curators seek to course-correct. On what advice she'd offer to the rookie-curator version of herself from 1986, Sarkar says, "When you curate, it's essential that you know what kind of story you want to tell. And if there's no story, that's fine, too. When you're selecting works, it should always be about 'quality over quantity'. That's where knowledge comes in, but, more importantly, that's where a good pair of eyes comes in. Not everybody who has knowledge of art history also has a good pair of eyes." ■

Aditya Mani Jha

ART

The Orientalists' Gaze

*Two Orientalist works acquired by **DAG**, which have never been displayed in India before, bring a fresh perspective to their subjects beyond the usual clichés*

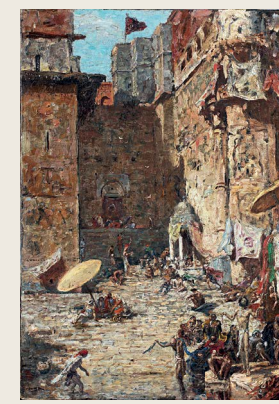
Among works by familiar greats like F.N. Souza, M.F. Husain, S.H. Raza, Nandalal Bose, Satish Gujral, Bikash Bhattacharjee and many more at the recently concluded third edition of *ICONIC*, DAG's exhibition series on 'Masterpieces of Indian Modern Art', two paintings stood out, Orientalist works being seen in India for the first time.

These are Edwin Lord Weeks' 'The Dance' and Marius Bauer's 'Benares'. "The idea behind *ICONIC* is to show some of the most exemplary works of art created in the country," says Kishore Singh, Senior VP, DAG. "These are museum-quality works with elements of rarity." Bauer's work is also part of *The Orientalists' Benares*, an exhibition opening on January 11 at DAG Mumbai as part of Mumbai Gallery Weekend.

The works of these later Orientalists, who were contemporaries of Raja Ravi Varma, bring new painting styles and sensibilities to bear on their subjects, marking a departure from visual documenters of India like the Daniells and William Hodges, who were more focused on accuracy.

An American artist, Edwin Lord Weeks (1849–1903) made three trips to India. Singh estimates that 'The Dance', which depicts a typical nautch, was painted on the third trip or following it. Nautch finds mention in Weeks' memoir, *From the Black Sea Through Persia and India* (1896), where he describes a performance on the ghats of Banaras:





VISUAL HISTORY
'The Dance' by Edwin Lord Weeks and (right) 'Benares' by Marius Bauer

"...a dainty little personage came forward...she was the living incarnation of the Nautch as interpreted by the sculptors of Chitor; from the air of laughing assurance with which she surveyed her assembled subjects, it was evident that she was accustomed to homage and sure of conquest."

Singh draws attention to the dancer's dress—"the detailing of her attire is very close to what you might see even today"—and the fine lattice screen from behind which a figure watches the proceedings. The backdrop is the tomb of Muhammad Shah Rangeela, which lies within Delhi's Nizamuddin Auliya dargah complex. This is possibly a case of juxtaposition, since such a dance is unlikely to have occurred here.

Bauer's painting couldn't be more stylistically different from Weeks' empathetic realism. The location has been identified as the Rana Mahal Ghat by Giles Tillotson, Senior VP, Exhibitions, at DAG. A Dutch artist, Bauer (1867–1932) came to India twice and was blown away by Banaras, which he painted extensively. Singh points out the deft use of light. "Like other artists of his age, Bauer wasn't looking for a strong physical resemblance," he says. "The style is impressionistic, photography having taken over the role of documentation by that time." The result is an arresting vision of Banaras, eternal and immediate.

These works will hopefully bring a breath of fresh air to the discourse on Orientalist art. ■

Amit Dixit